

The Saffron Rising

BJP gets its act together even as Advani's personal ratings soar. Better still, this comes at a time when UPA's fortune is on the decline.

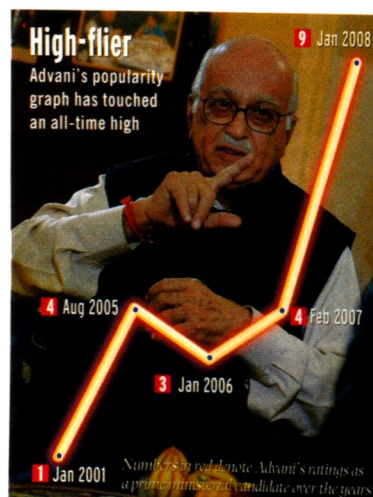
A few months ago, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, India's longest serving prime minister since Indira Gandhi, announced his retirement from active politics and anointed Lal Krishna Advani his successor. It was then believed that his departure would further handicap the coalition. But the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation poll shows that far from splintering, NDA is slowly consolidating and winning back hearts, and its leaders would hope, votes too. Since the shock debacle in 2004, six successive polls have shown it either stagnating or slipping. This poll shows the alliance gaining both in terms of the number of seats and vote percentage. NDA's vote share of 35.4 per cent and a tally of 181 seats is the highest these polls have given the alliance in the past four years. Even better, these accruals come when the Congress-led UPA has registered its biggest dip. To top it all is the sharp rise in Advani's popularity.

Signs of NDA's revival following the victory in Bihar came to an end after it lost the Maharashtra polls. But since then, there have been impressive wins in

Punjab and Uttarakhand. Victories in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh have further infused confidence amongst the leadership and cadres. In terms of semantics, BJP has got its act together. Advani has a pan-Indian appeal and along with Vajpayee is one of the architects of the party and also of NDA.

NDA also has an advantage over UPA, which is in the unenviable position of having to run with the hare and hunt with the hound. BJP's partnerships are sound and time-tested. Congress, on the other hand, is ruling with the Left's support and if elections are held the next year, the two will be involved in street brawls in Kerala and West Bengal, before—who knows—deciding to sup once again in the name of secularism. Though Mamata Bannerjee cannot make up her mind about her being a part of NDA, another equally formidable lady is sending all the right messages. If J. Jayalalithaa joins in, it will more than make up for the loss of Chandrababu Naidu who broke off soon after the 2004 debacle.

by Priya Sahgal



BJP's image since its defeat in the 2004 polls has...

37
(39)

REMAINED THE SAME

Improved	34	2001
Deteriorated	13	20
Is finished as a party	2	3

All figures in per cent Rest: Don't know/Can't say

Will Advani's anointment as NDA's prime ministerial candidate improve its poll prospects?

37

HAVE POSITIVE EFFECT

No effect	32
Have a negative effect	11

All figures in per cent Rest: Don't know/Can't say